Problem Set 8

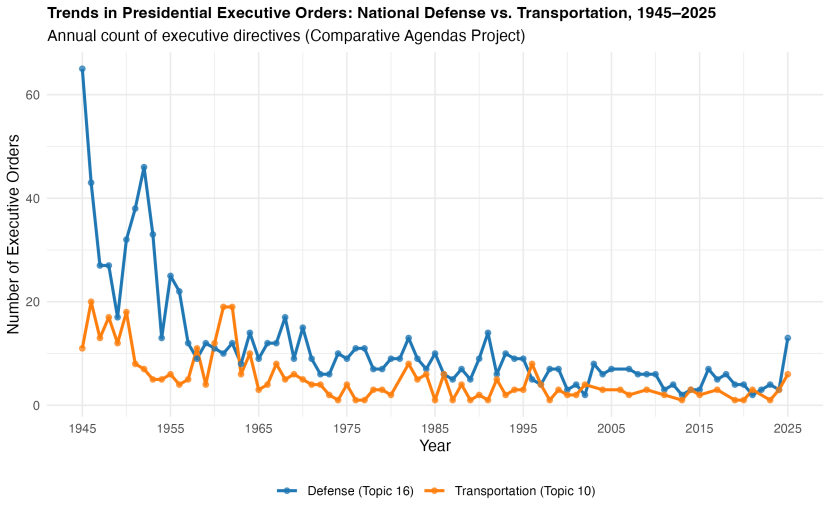
Kerri Rose Riley

Background: For my MPA Capstone, my group has been paired with Seaspan, a shipbuilding, repair, and maintenance company. Our project focus is centered around Executive Order 14269, "Restoring America's Maritime Dominance", which was passed by President Trump on April 9, 2025. For this analysis, I decided to conduct my research on how presidential and legislative attention has historically shifted across national defense and transportation policy, and how the institutional division of labor between executive orders and enacted laws shapes defense procurement and military readiness.

What follows are three visualizations showing…

- Figure 1: Trends in Presidential Executive Orders: National Defense (Topic 16) vs. Transportation (Topic 10), 1945–2025
- Figure 2: Executive Priorities in Transportation: Maritime Policy vs General Transit, 1945-2025
- Figure 3: Executive Priorities in Defense: Military Readiness & Strategic Mobilization (Subtopic 1604) vs. Weapons & Naval Procurement (Subtopic 1610), 1945–2025
- Figure 4: Institutional Division of Labor in Defense Procurement: Presidential Orders vs. Enacted Legislation (Subtopic 1610), 1945–2025
- Figure 5: Institutional Division of Labor in Military Readiness: Presidential Orders vs. Enacted Legislation (Subtopic 1604), 1945–2025

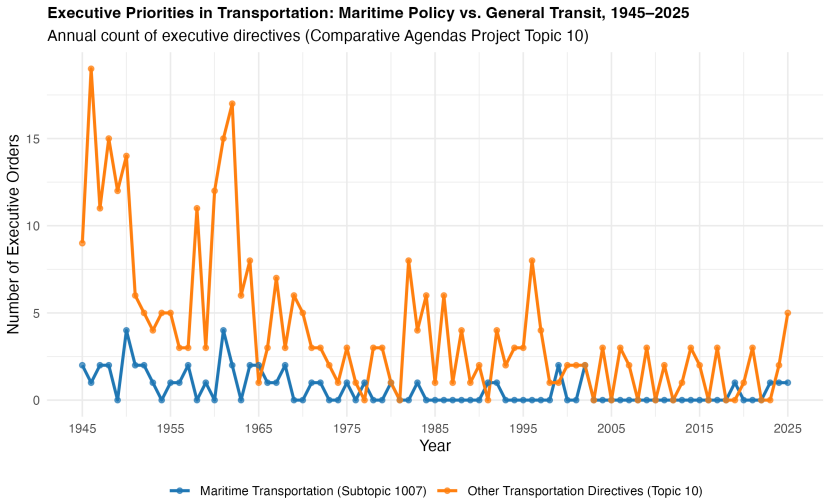
Figure 1



Topic 16 covers all 18 defense subtopics combined (intelligence, nuclear arms, personnel, procurement, alliances, etc), while Topic 10 captures 7 transportation subtopics (highways, aviation, maritime, mass transit, etc).

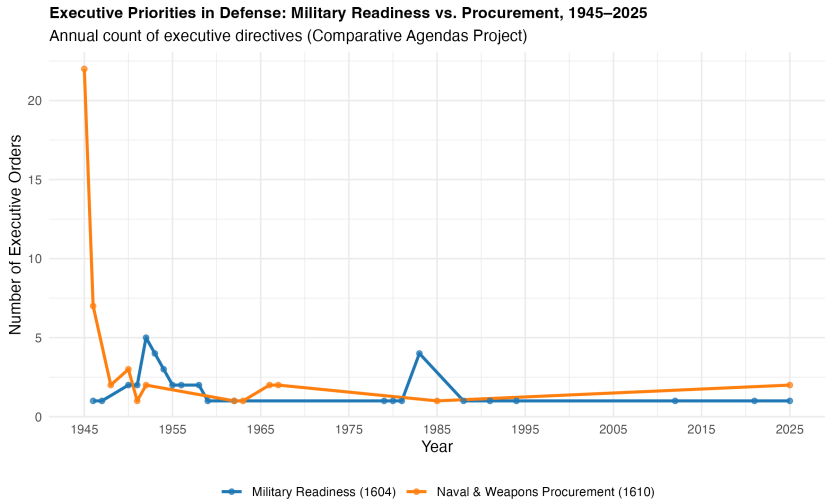
Key Takeaways: This graph shows overall macro-level executive attention. Defense EOs spiked during post-WWII demobilization (1945) and the Korean War(1950-1953), but both categories dropped to a low, stable baseline by the 1980s.

Figure 2



Maritime policy historically remains low and flat, typically averaging between 0 and 2 directives per year. Both general transportation and maritime policy show a sharp upward tick in 2025. Executive Order 14269 (Restoring America's Maritime Dominance) is classified under Subtopic 1007 due to its focus on commercial shipyards, port entry fees, harbor maintenance taxes, and merchant marine capacity.

Figure 3

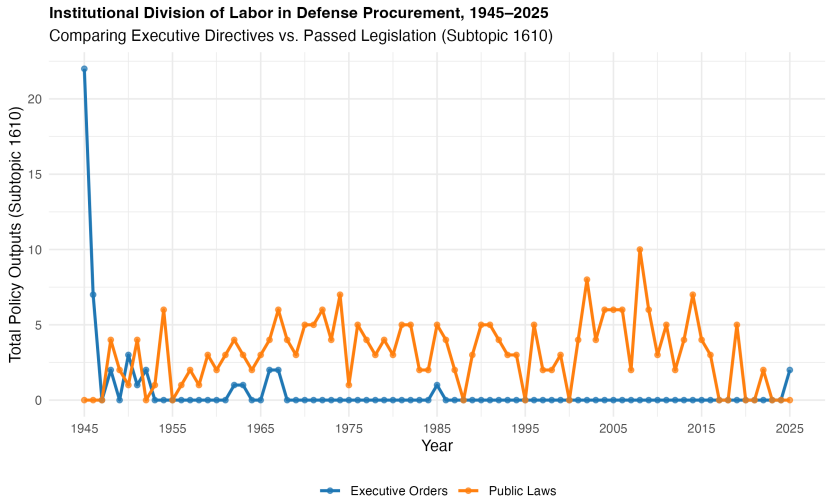


1604 (Readiness): Includes issues related to military readiness, coordination of armed services air support and sealift capabilities, and national stockpiles of strategic materials.

1610 (Procurement): Includes issues related to military procurement, conversion of old equipment, and weapons systems evaluation (including naval and shipbuilding contracts).

Key Takeaways: - 1945–1950 Spike in Procurement (1610): Post-WWII industrial reconversion required massive executive management (canceling war contracts, decommissioning naval vessels, reorganizing shipyards). - Post-1955 it flat-lined: Executive Orders specifically targeted at procurement and readiness have plummeted to near-zero counts per year. - Modern presidents rarely use unilateral Executive Orders to address defense procurement or industrial readiness.

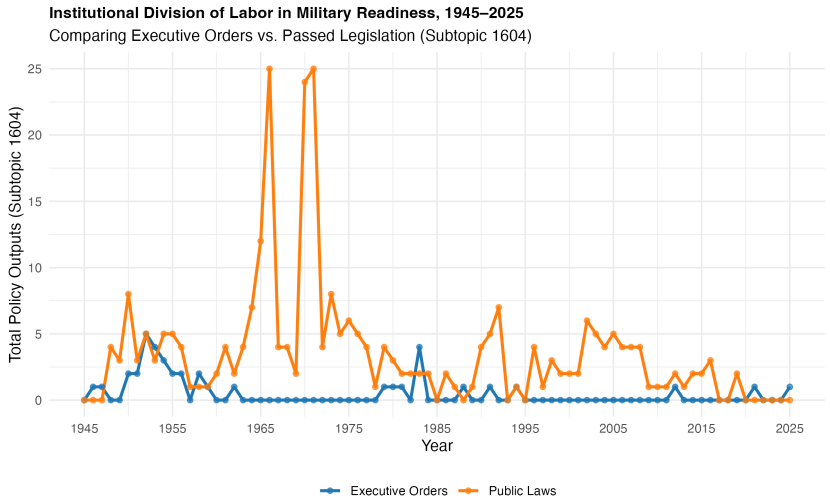
Figure 4



Subtopic 1610 explicitly captures policy outputs governing weapons acquisition, fleet modernization, and military industrial base contracts.

Key Takeaways: - This graph shows Congress consistently dominates policy output via Public Laws, while unilateral Executive Orders remain at zero for decades. Rebuilding the Navy requires Congressional statutory funding.

Figure 5



Subtopic 1604 covers operational readiness, sealift capabilities, strategic material stockpiles, and force mobilization.

Key Takeaways: - This graph shows that Congress drives major policy overhauls through large legislative spikes, whereas presidential EOs only appear as minor operational triggers during specific national crises.